

The Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island

By John P. Harrigan

Foreward

When I started this paper, I was a second year Electrical Engineering Major at Cal Poly Pomona. As a part of the requirements for Dr. Urcia's English 105 Class, we were assigned a research paper, complete with footnotes. I had just seen the movie, "The Island of the Blue Dolphins," and I thought that this might be a good subject for the paper. Little did I know where this simple English 105 assignment would take me. Among other things it instilled in me a love and fascination for the history of our country and, in particular, our great state of California.

All of this could not have been possible without the help and assistance of the staff of the Southwest Museum in Los Angeles, California. Allowing a nineteen-year-old college student to physically touch and read through their priceless manuscripts was an act unheard of at other historical libraries. Reading through these old documents brought the story to life for me.

However, having access to all of the documents did not make the task any easier. Many times there were conflicting statements from the various sources. Sometimes they were minor points, while at other times they required even more searching to discover or learn the truth. I hope that all of my efforts bring the story of Juana Maria alive for you as it has for me.

The Islands

Of all the stories that can be found about the Channel Islands off the coast of California, there is one that goes far beyond all others in its strangeness and mystery. It is the account of the Indian woman who has been referred to as the "Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island." The story is something of a mystery because all of the facts are not known and never will be. For this article, all reliable information that could be found

has been studied and compared in the hope of obtaining a clear picture of what actually happened on San Nicolas Island.

Some nine miles long and three and a half miles wide, the island is located approximately seventy miles from Port Hueneme, California. Robert M. Norriss described it as "a faulted asymmetric anticline, composed of Pleistocene sediments lying uncomfortably on Eocene sandstone and shale."¹ In simpler terms, the island has a 907 foot peak toward the ocean side and south of the center. It is made up of varying layers of cracked rock and sediments that are bent in opposite directions from the peak. Because of the high winds and storms that bombard the island, it is slowly wearing away and will probably disappear in time. The island is surrounded by reefs and shallow water. The sea is extremely rough in this area, and the only time that one can safely land or leave the island is around six o'clock in the morning.² There are no good harbors for a ship to find refuge from wind or storm.

It is a bird island, once being covered with thousands of ravens, cormorants, sea gulls, blue herons, bald eagles, larks and robins.³ Other occupants of this desolate land were seals, otter and sea lions.

The first European to see San Nicolas Island was Bartolome Ferrer who sailed past it in 1543. Sebastian Vizcaino sailed past the island in 1602, but neither Ferrer nor Vizcaino set foot on it.⁴ On December 6, 1602, Juan Cabrillo was the first European to actually land on the island.⁵

According to Cabrillo, the island was densely populated by a superior race of Indians which A. L. Kroeber classifies as of the Gabrielino or Shoshone stock.⁶ Cabrillo's report states that the men wore loose cloaks while the women wore petticoats and capes of sealskins, heavily fringed and handsomely ornamented with shells and stones. If a woman wanted to look different from others and was very industrious, she embroidered her garments with pearls and small

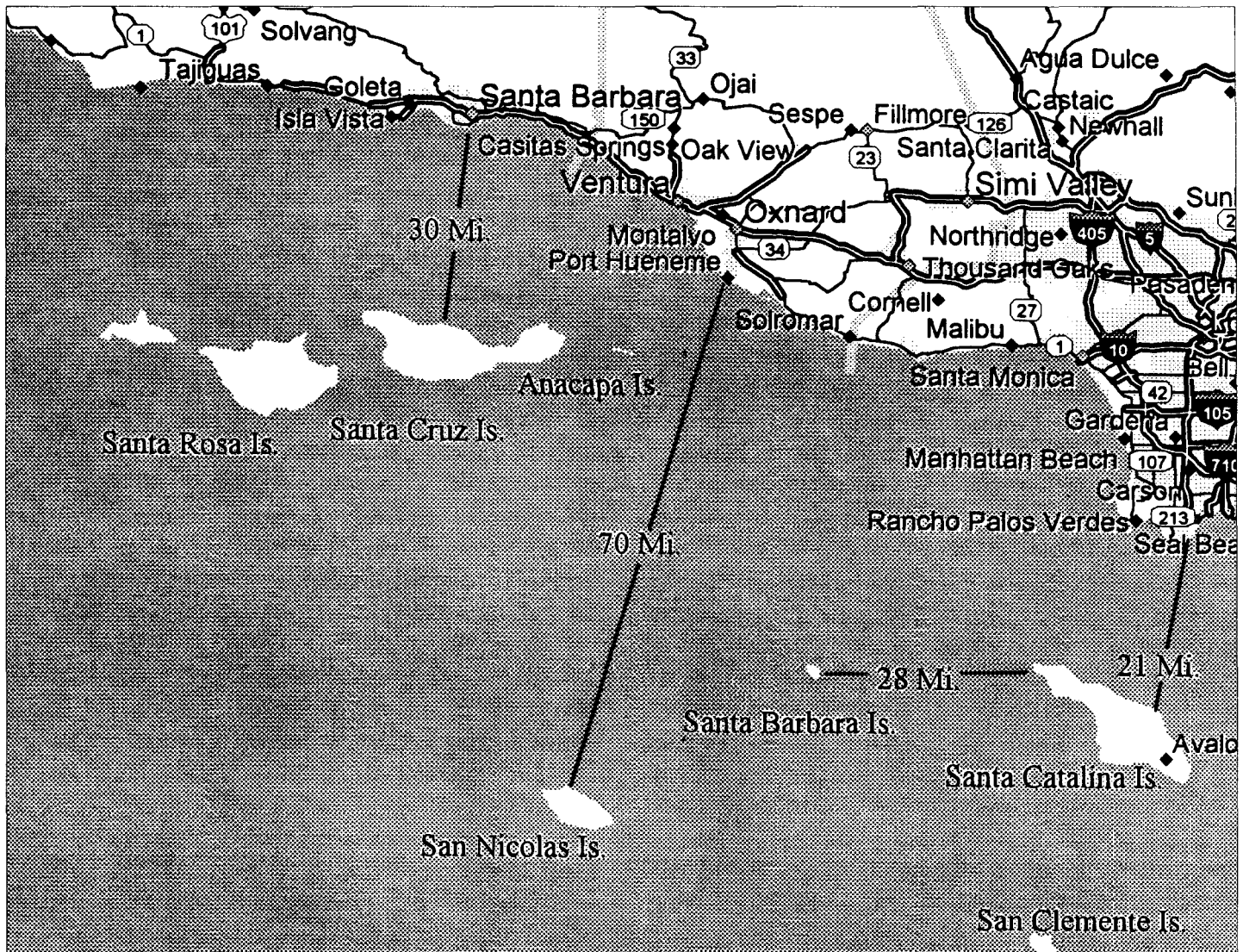
pink shells. A semi-caste system existed on the island. The higher a woman rated on the social scale, the more ornamentation she had on her garments. She might also wear stone necklaces and iris-hued abalone earrings.⁷

The Indian inhabitants of San Nicolas Island were described as a peaceful tribe because no warlike weapons have ever been found.⁸ "The children had light hair and ruddy cheeks. The women had fine forms, beautiful eyes, and a modest demeanor."⁹ They lived on abalone, fish, sea lions, sea elephants and birds.¹⁰ In order to be in the best location for the food of the season, they moved from one site to another. This is demonstrated by the fact that some sixty-eight sites have been found where villages existed, but not all of

these were inhabited at the same time. It is estimated that, at their peak, these villages supported over one thousand Indians.¹¹

The Indians manufactured water-tight baskets and soapstone vessels for cooking. They also made needles, awls, ollas (pottery water jars) of stone and other useful utensils. Their canoes were made long and deep with both ends elevated at the same degree to allow travel in both directions. According to Mons de Cessac, an archaeologist for the French government, all of these products showed evidence of superior workmanship and had excellent form.¹²

Not a great deal is known about the islanders or what happened to them from 1602 to around 1800. During this period the population began to fall in great



San Nicolas Island is located in the Channel Islands about 70 miles from Port Hueneme off the coast of Southern California. Juan Cabrillo was the first European to land on the island in 1602.

numbers. This was probably due to diseases carried by the white men who stopped at the island for hunting.

In the year 1811, a ship belonging to Pope and Boardman of Boston and commanded by a Captain Whittemore¹³ brought twenty-five to thirty Kodiaks from the Russian camp at Sitka to San Nicolas Island for the purpose of hunting otter and seal. After the Kodiaks were supplied with guns and provisions, they were left on the island while the ship sailed off to other business, with Whittemore's promise to return at the end of the year to pick them up.¹⁴ During the time that the ship was away, a feud broke out between the Indians and the Kodiaks. The feud had to do with the seizure of the island women by the Kodiaks. In the battle that ensued, a majority of the island men were massacred, both young and old alike,¹⁵ and the island women were forced to live with the Kodiaks for the remainder of their stay. At the end of the year the ship came to remove the Kodiaks and the skins which they had collected during the year but that is, in fact, all they did. "The islanders were left to their fate."¹⁶

Removing the Survivors

From that time to about 1830, there are no records of what happened to those who were left on the island. Because of the extremely poor living conditions on the various Channel Islands, the Franciscan Mission Fathers decided to bring all of the Indians from the islands to the mainland. This was to be done in order to preserve the races from extinction as well as to improve their conditions.¹⁷

By 1835, the task had been carried out on all of the islands except San Nicolas. This island was left until last because it was the most distant and there were no ships available for the long voyage. In 1835, the Mission Fathers of Santa Barbara were able to charter a twenty-ton schooner with the aid of Isaac J. Sparks, Lewis F. Burton and Bill Williams of the Chino Ranch of Los Angeles.¹⁸ The ship *Peor es Nada* or "Better Than Nothing," was commanded by Captain Charles Hubbard. These men along with about twelve crew members sailed to the island on August 1, 1835, to remove the Indians.¹⁹ It is interesting to note that, at one time or another, each one of the men was credited with having been captain of the ship. However, records in-

dicate that Charles Hubbard was the captain.²⁰

The evacuation was carried out under the direction of Captain Bill Williams, the Collector of the Port of San Pedro.²¹ By the time the rescue party arrived, the number of Indians found on the island is uncertain. The high figure is around forty men, women and children.²² The low figure is two women and one man who was without all of his faculties because of a blow over the head sustained during the Kodiak battle.²³ The more widely accepted, and more reasonable figure, is around seventeen or eighteen men, women and children.²⁴

In the confusion of moving from the island, a child was misplaced or became lost. When this was discovered, the launch which was to take the Indians to the larger vessel was thoroughly searched. Since the child was not found in the boat, the rocks and beach were searched. There was no child or any sign of a child anywhere. The mother pleaded to be allowed to return inland to continue the search. The captain reluctantly gave his permission.²⁵

Not long after the woman went inland, the winds began to increase in velocity. The sea became rough and storm clouds appeared. The captain and the crew began to grow anxious because of the woman's delay in returning to the boat. The storm grew in intensity and finally reached a point where it was no longer safe for the launch or the schooner to remain in the area. At this time, they set out for the safety of the mainland and left the woman alone on the island.²⁶

The woman was described as a widow between twenty and thirty years-of-age, of medium height, fine in form, light in complexion and with dark brown hair.²⁷ This would mean that she was a child at the time of the Kodiak affair or was an offspring of one of them.

There is a great deal of confusion about how the woman was left on the island. Some say that the woman reached the schooner before she discovered her child missing. When she found that they were going out to sea in the storm instead of remaining in the area to continue the search for her child, she jumped overboard and swam back to the island for her child.²⁸ Another story is that she was inland and not with the other Indians when the ship arrived; thus, she was left behind.²⁹ While her diving from the boat makes a nice story, it is highly improbable that this event actually

occurred.

The original story is substantiated by George Nidever who talked with Isaac Sparks, and by other first-hand accounts. Furthermore, the launch used at the time was not a large craft and it would have been rather difficult to lose a child of nursing age in a small boat without someone knowing it. An investigation of first-hand accounts and interviews that have been recorded shows that the Emma C. Hardacre's story about the Indian woman diving from the ship is inaccurate, as are her reports of several other events.

When the *Peor es Nada* reached San Pedro, some of the Indians were sent to Los Angeles and others to the San Gabriel Mission. Two of the women soon married wealthy men in the Los Angeles area, one of whom was Bill Williams of the rescue party.³⁰ The man who was injured in battle, and who was supposed to have been without all of his faculties, remained in San Pedro among the hunters. It is said he was strong enough to do the work of three or four normal men.³¹

Captain Hubbard intended to return to the island after the storm to find the woman and her child. However, before he could do so, he had two other commitments to fulfill. The first of these was to take George Nidever to the islands of Santa Rosa and San Miguel for otter hunting in September, 1835. Among those present on the hunt was Mr. Sparks, who told Mr. Nidever of the Indian woman.³² It is ironic that George Nidever, who was, in a way, responsible for the woman's being left on the island, was so influential in her finally being found. Captain Hubbard's second task was to take a load of lumber from San Pedro to San Francisco. On this voyage, the ship capsized at the Golden Gate, was washed out to sea and captured by the Russians.³³ After the loss of the *Peor es Nada*, it was impossible to make any effort to rescue the woman because there was no other ship available that was large enough to make the trip safely.³⁴

By this time, the woman was given up for dead because of the wild dogs that roamed the island.³⁵ It is interesting to note that these wild dogs, which were so troublesome, had once been the prized animals of the Indians. However, over the years, the dogs grew in numbers to a point where they were no longer welcome.

After California became a State, some interest was aroused again in San Nicolas Island but it did not have

to do with the woman. Everyone had forgotten about her except Father Gonzales of the Santa Barbara Mission. When a European, Tom Jeffries, obtained a ship and expressed a desire to explore the island, Father Gonzales offered him \$200 to bring the woman or her child or both back alive.³⁶ When Jeffries' ship returned to Santa Barbara, people lined the shore waiting for the signal to indicate he found the woman, but no signal was given. The woman was soon forgotten again, but the trip was not. The otter and seal that had once populated the island had returned, and hunting there would once again be excellent.

The Search

As California grew, the size and number of ships on the coast increased. The Gold Rush in 1849 undoubtedly had some influence on this. Finally, with larger ships available, George Nidever went to San Nicolas Island in April, 1852, and he took Mr. Jeffries along with him on this trip. They planned to collect sea gull eggs which were in great demand at that time.

The landing party, made up of Mr. Nidever, Mr. Jeffries and two Indians, set foot on the island six or seven miles from the southern tip. About two-hundred yards from the beach, they found human footprints. They were small in size and could not have been those of a man. Because the intact prints were sunk into the dried and cracked ground, it was concluded that they had been made shortly after a rainstorm when the ground was soft.

A few hundred yards, still farther from the beach and about two miles apart, the group found three small circular huts made of sage brush. These huts stood about five feet high, six feet in diameter and showed signs of lack of use for some period of time. There were several poles, four-to-six feet high outside each hut. Seal blubber, which appeared to be at least three months old, had been stuck on the top of each pole and out of the reach of the dogs. Upon seeing these signs, the group was convinced that someone was on the island, as Isaac Sparks had said. Before any further searching could be done, a gale came up and forced them to return to their ship. Even though they were on the southern side of the island, they were blown about a great deal. After eight days, they sailed to Santa Barbara Island for shelter and returned to the

mainland of Santa Barbara when the gale subsided.³⁷

Upon hearing of the discovery of the footprints, Father Gonzales asked that they make every effort to find the woman. After taking a load of lumber to Santa Cruz, Nidever returned to Santa Barbara and outfitted his ship for an otter and seal hunt on San Nicolas Island. On this trip, Nidever had a man named Carl Dittman, alias Charles Brown, and two Indians along with him, in addition to the regular crew.

They landed on the island at the southern end and Nidever, Dittman and the Indians went ashore to see where the otter lay. They found nothing of the woman on this landing. On the third day, they landed toward the northern end of the island. The Indians were left to watch the boat while Nidever and Dittman started toward the headland. About one-half mile from the headland they came upon a wide, low, sandy flat that extended from one side of the island to the other. They started across on the edge of the flat (which side is not known). In the crotch of a small Malva Real tree they found a small basket woven out of grass, about three-feet long, one-and-a-half feet wide, and some fourteen-inches deep. It was covered with a piece of sealskin.³⁸

They removed the basket from its perch and uncovered it. Inside they found a dress made of cormorant shag (skins of birds sewn together with the feathers pointing downward). The basket also contained several square pieces of shag, bone needles and knives, fish hooks made of abalone shell, and a rope made of sinews which was a half-inch in diameter and about 25-feet long. Dittman noted that the rope compared with the best of its day on the mainland. The men concluded that the rope had been used to snare seals for food.³⁹ All of these items were neatly placed in the basket. Nidever wanted to spread the articles around and then return to see if the woman had replaced them. Dittman was opposed to disturbing the things, but finally agreed to having them spread about.

The next two or three days were spent hunting. Then a strong wind came up and soon increased to a gale. The men remained on the island about a week hoping that the storm would blow itself out and allow them to go ashore and check on the basket. However, since the storm showed no signs of abating they left for the safety of the mainland. Dittman reported that Nidever was so excited about finding the basket he almost ran the ship on a reef at San Miguel Island

where they stopped and found shelter.⁴⁰

Once again, there is some confusion about this second trip to the island. Dittman's story seems to make the most sense. In three different reports by Nidever, he has varying stories. In one case, it appears that the report could be in error. This discrepancy has to do with the finding of footprints and a piece of driftwood. Dittman and Nidever both reported this on the third trip⁴¹ but, in one of Nidever's reports, he said it occurred on the second trip.⁴² This point is rather minor. The important thing is that they all agree on finding the basket.

Another point of controversy arises in the reports concerning the dogs on the island. They were said to have looked like coyotes, but they were white and black.⁴³ If they actually had been coyotes, they would have been mottled light brown, white and grey. Both men agree on seeing the dogs but they disagree on which trip, the second or third. It is possible that since these dogs roamed the entire island, they could have seen them both times. Nidever reports that seven or eight dogs were seen on the second trip in 1852.⁴⁴ Dittman mentions seeing only two or three on the third trip in 1853.⁴⁵

There is some discrepancy in the reports regarding the starting date of the third trip. Was it June, July or August? All sources consulted state that the Indian woman lived only three months from the time that she was found. In the book of Burials of Santa Barbara Mission, entry Number 1183 records the burial of the Indian woman (Juana Maria), and it is dated October 19, 1853.⁴⁶ This would mean that she had to be found sometime in late July or early August, 1853. The exact date is not known or, at least it could not be found in any of the primary sources.

During the summer of 1853, Nidever refitted his ship for another otter hunt on the Channel Islands. The men hoped for better weather this time since it was summer and they did not expect storms. First, they went to San Miguel Island, but there is no record of how long they stayed there. If they remained there a week or two, the reports of starting the trip in June, 1853, would be very plausible.⁴⁷

After leaving San Miguel Island they headed toward San Nicolas Island, arriving there in the early afternoon. Again, there is no record of how long the trip took. However, since it was seventy miles from

San Pedro, and still farther from Santa Barbara, it can be assumed that the trip took one or two days.

They landed on the northeast, or inland side, at about the middle of the island. As soon as they anchored, Dittman, Nidever and two Indians went ashore to see where the otter lay. When they reached the shore, the Indians were left to watch the boat while Dittman and Nidever went on ahead. They started off toward the head of the island and Dittman reported seeing several dogs. They were very wild and ran away as soon as they saw the men.⁴⁸

When they reached the head of the island, Nidever wanted to sit down and rest while Dittman went on ahead along the shore on the seaward side of the island. After walking for some distance, he found footprints leading from the beach, up over a bank and toward the ridge above. He followed them until they disappeared in a thick moss that covered the ground. Nidever reported that there was a matted area in the moss that looked as if the woman had sat down to rest before going on.⁴⁹

Dittman returned to Nidever and told him what he had found. At first, Nidever thought that the footprints must have been made by the Indians they had brought with them, but changed his mind when he saw the size of the footprints. They were too small for either of the Indians. Furthermore, it would have been impossible for the Indians to have gone ahead of them without being noticed.

Because of the dogs they had seen earlier, Nidever did not think that they would find the woman alive or even find her remains. In spite of this belief, he decided to search that end of the island thoroughly the following day. Since it was getting late, they started toward the boat and discontinued their search for the day.

The following morning after they had finished breakfast, the entire crew, except for the cook, went ashore to search. Dittman took three Indians and an Irishman named Colorado and started out for the sandy flat. Arriving there, they spread out in a straight line and walked from one side of the island to the other. This pass brought no results. Dittman then sent the men back to search the edges, and especially the area where the basket had been found on the previous trip. Dittman headed toward the spot where he had found the footprints the night before. When he located them,

he followed them up over the bank and up the side of the ridge until they ended. He continued up the ridge in the same direction as the footprints until he found a piece of driftwood which, he concluded, the Indian woman had probably dropped on her way back to her camp.

From this point on the ridge, Dittman could see three huts farther up the ridge. On closer investigation, he found that the huts were made of whale's ribs and covered with brush. Grass was growing inside them and there were other signs that the huts had not been used for a long time. From the huts, Dittman could see all of the men moving about below him. He looked around the area and, at some distance on the northeast side of the ridge and about half way up, he saw what appeared to be a crow moving about in the brush. As he came closer, he found that it was the woman with her head and shoulders showing over the top of an enclosure like those previously described. Dittman was able to get within several yards of the woman because she was facing the other direction and did not notice him. As he came closer, two dogs that were by the hut began to growl. As soon as they started to growl, the woman yelled and they ran away.

From this vantage point with the men still in sight, Dittman placed his hat on the ramrod of his rifle and raised and lowered it to attract the attention of his men. When they finally saw his signal, he motioned for them to come to where he was standing. As the men were closing in, the woman saw them. She shaded her eyes and looked every few minutes, all the while talking to herself very rapidly.

As he waited for his men to come closer, Dittman had a chance to observe the woman and her surroundings.

.... She was seated cross legged on the ground and was engaged in separating the blubber from a piece of seal skin which was lying across one knee and held by one hand. In the other hand she grasped a crude knife, a piece of iron hoop thrust into a rough piece of wood for a handle and held so that the back of the hand was turned down, scraping and cutting from, instead of toward her. Just outside of the enclosure there was a high pile of ashes and bones showing that she had lived in this place for some time. Baskets of grass and vessels of the same ma-

terial made in the shape of a flagon and lined with asphaltum, used to hold water, were scattered about. On a sinew rope stretched between two poles, several feet above the ground were hanging pieces of seal blubber, while near her was the head of a seal from which the brains, already putrid were running. Her covering consisted of a single garment of the shag's skin, the feathers out and pointed downward, in shape resembling a loose gown. It was sleeveless, low in the neck and was girded at the waist with a sinew rope. When she stood up, as I afterwards observed, it extended nearly to the ankles. She had no covering on her head; her hair which was thickly matted and bleached a reddish brown, hung down her shoulders.⁵⁰

As soon as the men had come close enough for Dittman to signal to them, he ordered them to circle the woman to prevent her escaping. When they were still some distance away, but not so far as to allow the woman to escape, Dittman stepped out in front of her. Instead of running, as he thought she might, she seemed very happy to see him. She began talking and gesticulating, but none of this was intelligible to him. As each of the men approached her the woman bowed in greeting and started talking to them. During this time Dittman signaled to Nidever who was below on the beach and took no great part in the search.⁵¹

When all of the men had arrived at her camp, the woman had them sit down. Then she took two types of roots and placed them in the fire to roast. When they were done, she took them out and passed them around to the men and made signs for them to eat. According to both Dittman and Nidever, one of the roots was called a *carcomite* by the Californians.⁵²

All of the Indians in the group tried to converse with the woman, but all proved unsuccessful except in sign language. Nidever asked the Indians if they thought that they could handle the woman if they had to remove her forcibly. They said that it would be no problem but Dittman said that force would not be necessary.

Nidever tried to show the woman in sign language that she was to go with them back to the mainland, but she was not able to understand Nidever and was confused. Dittman attracted her attention by tapping her on the shoulder. Then he took one of her baskets

and went through the motions of packing and the woman understood this very well. She understood even better when Dittman said, "Vamoose." When she heard this word she quickly went to work packing all of her things including the seal's head.⁵³

When everything was packed, she picked up as much as she could carry and the men picked up the rest. She started off toward the beach but Nidever, still not trusting her, had two Indians lead with Dittman and himself following the woman to prevent her escape. They stopped to rest at a pool of fresh water near the beach and noticed that the surface of this pool always seemed to be rippled as if a breeze were blowing over it. Dittman observed the strange phenomenon on this occasion and on several future stops at the pool.⁵⁴

There were several poles around the pool on which the men hung the articles they had been carrying. They made signs for the woman to do the same thing. She did so without hesitation. They noticed that there were bones in the cracks and fissures of the rocks around the pond. The men concluded that the woman had left the bones there because she carried bones in one of her baskets and occasionally she would suck on a bone and then put it back in the basket. From time to time she took bits of food from her basket and ate it. Dittman says that she never ate much at one time but that she ate several times during the day.⁵⁵

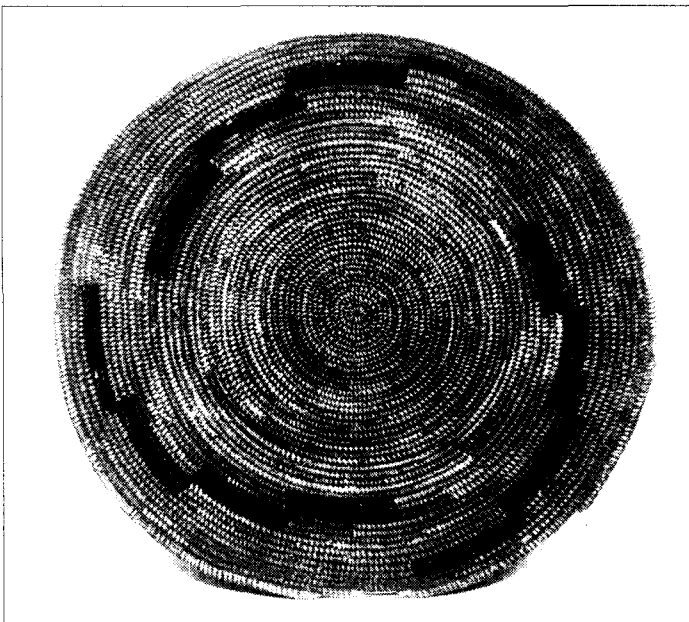
After they rested the party continued along the bank until they came to another pool. At this point the woman made signs that she wished to bathe. The crew went on ahead to the boat and Dittman and Nidever withdrew until she was finished. When she returned they proceeded walking on to the beach. She understood their signs telling her to get into the boat. After boarding, she went to the bow and sat down, placing one hand on each side of the boat.

Arriving at the schooner, the woman climbed aboard and went to the galley where she made signs to indicate that it was warm and it seemed to please her. At dinner time the crew gave the woman some of their food which she ate without any signs that it disagreed with her.⁵⁶

That afternoon, Dittman made the woman her first "civilized" clothes in order to preserve the unusual cormorant feather gown she was wearing. Her new outfit consisted of a petticoat made of ticking, a man's

shirt, a black necktie and an old cape which Nidever gave to her. While Dittman was making her petticoat she laughed at his method of sewing. About this time, Nidever gave her the cape which was badly in need of mending. Since her eyes seemed to be weak, she could not see to thread the needle and Dittman threaded it for her so that she could mend the cape. Her method was rather unusual. She placed the cloth between her legs, then thrust the needle through the cloth with one hand and then pulled the needle the remainder of the way with the other hand. In spite of its crudeness, her method proved to be successful. She was very pleased with her new clothes and wanted everyone to notice her wearing them.⁵⁷

The next day the crew went ashore in the same location to set up a camp for otter hunting. They put up a tent for themselves and a hut-type shelter for the woman. They remained on the island for nearly a month. During this time, the men were gone nearly all day, but the woman kept busy collecting firewood and water for the camp. She did this willingly and without ever being asked. She always wanted to help in any way that she could. While working, she talked, laughed and sang. If she wasn't helping out in the camp she was weaving baskets. She worked on several baskets at one time, going from one to the other. As a result, she never finished any that she had started.⁵⁸



An example of Gabrielino basketry made with coiled stitches of juncas, sumac & grasses.

The woman seemed to like the type of food the men prepared. Only once did she show any sign of returning to her old source of food. On this occasion Dittman killed a female otter and dragged it ashore to skin it. After it was skinned he was going to dispose of the carcass. The woman stopped him and scolded him for the waste of meat. She dragged the carcass up the beach and left it. After a few days, however, the carcass began to smell, and when the crew went to dispose of it, the woman made no objections. In fact, Dittman says, she made signs to get rid of it because of the smell.⁵⁹

The otter was within a few days of giving birth when it had been shot. The unborn otter was removed from the female, skinned and stuffed, and given to the woman. She hung it by a string in her shelter and played with it for hours, hitting it to keep it in motion.⁶⁰

Having completed their hunt, the group packed to leave the island. After their departure, such a violent storm arose that they thought they would have to return to the island for safety. During the storm the woman made signs that she could stop the wind. She knelt down on the deck facing the wind and seemed to be praying. She did this a number of times during the day, and when the wind stopped that afternoon, she smiled and made signs that her prayers had been answered. The night was spent on the lee side of Santa Cruz Island and the next morning they set out for the Santa Barbara mainland.⁶¹

As they sailed into Santa Barbara harbor, the woman saw an ox-cart on the shore. She pointed to it and danced and laughed the entire time it was in sight. One of Nidever's sons had come on horseback to greet them as they came ashore and the woman ran around the horse pointing, laughing and dancing.⁶²

After his arrival in Santa Barbara, Nidever took the woman to stay at his home. While she was there she often went into town, but she never came home without some gifts for the children. Many people stopped at Santa Barbara to see her; some brought gifts which she accepted but did not open. After the people had gone, she would take great delight in giving the gifts to the children of the house. The woman was always in good spirits and sang and danced when people came.⁶³

In an effort to find someone who could speak the

woman's language, the Mission Fathers sent for the Indians from surrounding areas. It is not clear if they were unable to find a translator or, if those who came could not converse with her. It is not unlikely that, over the period of eighteen years, she had developed a language of her own. She must have heard the language of the hunters who came to the island during those the years, because she used such words as *pickininy* in referring to her child, and *manana*.⁶⁴

In sign language, the woman told Nidever and others that, "....she did not find her child, that she wandered for days without tasting any food or drink, sometimes sleeping but [a] little, until her clothes were torn, and her feet and legs bleeding."⁶⁵

The fact that she did not find her child is recorded in several different accounts by Nidever, and it can be assumed to be true. The stories about her finding the child and its being partially devoured by the dogs came from sources that have proved to be erroneous in several instances. The fact that the woman did not find her child would tend to discount the claim of Arthur R. Sanger of Los Angeles who says that he has the skeleton of the child.⁶⁶

With regard to the child, Nidever continues in his report:

*After a time she forgot her child and sang and danced. She also told that she was very sick at one time; that she had seen vessels passing two [sic] and fro but none came to take her off; that she saw us on the island before we found her. ... About 5 weeks after she was brought over, she was taken sick from eating too much fruit and 7 weeks from the day of her arrival died.*⁶⁷

While the Indian woman was ill, Mrs. Nidever cared for her. She cooked some seal blubber for her but the woman would not eat it and pointed to her worn teeth. Before she died, the Mission Fathers baptized her *sub conditione* (conditionally, because they did not know if she had been baptized before) and named her Juana Maria. She was buried in the Mission cemetery on October 19, 1853. The burial record is Number 1183 on Folio 13 of the Register of Burials of the Presidio of Santa Barbara.

The woman's possessions were great curiosities. One of her two water-tight baskets was given to some

unknown person who reported this along with a picture of the basket to *Hutchings' California Magazine*.⁶⁸ Her dress and several other articles were reportedly sent to Rome's Vatican Museum, but there have been no reliable reports of their ever having been seen. The remainder of her things, and probably the dress, were sent to San Francisco, where they were lost in the 1906 earthquake.⁶⁹

In 1928 a plaque was erected on the church wall in the Santa Barbara Mission Cemetery. It reads as follows:

JUANA MARIA
INDIAN WOMAN ABANDONED ON
SAN NICOLAS ISLAND EIGHTEEN YEARS
FOUND AND BROUGHT TO
SANTA BARBARA
BY
CAPT. GEORGE NIDEVER
IN 1853
SANTA BARBARA CHAPTER
DAUGHTERS OF THE
AMERICAN REVOLUTION
1928



A picture of the plaque to Juana Maria in the cemetery at the Santa Barbara Mission. It is mounted on the north wall of the bell tower.

It is almost beyond the grasp of a normal person to imagine how a human being could be left alone for eighteen years on an island and still remain as happy and cheerful as did Juana Maria and all of the time hoping and waiting for her rescue.

Epilogue

One might wonder what has happened to Juana Maria and to San Nicolas Island since 1853. No one knows where the remains of Juana Maria, or most others, are buried in the Santa Barbara Mission Cemetery. The practice of that day was to dig up the bones of all

of those in an area and re-bury them in a common grave when the cemetery filled up. For this reason, the plaque to Juana Maria is on the wall of the Church in the Mission Cemetery and not on any particular plot of ground.

At one time or another, sheep were run on many of the Channel Islands, totally destroying any natural vegetation on the islands. As a result, they are slowly being worn away. In a conversation with the Navy's Ecologist, Mr. Ron Dow, in October of 1982, I learned that there were no otter on San Nicolas Island, but there were large numbers of sea lions and sea elephants. The island is indeed wearing away and Mr. Dow and oth-

San Nicolas Island Today

San Nicolas is one of the eight Channel Islands off the southern California coast and contains over 20 square miles of gently rolling terrain accented with steep sea cliffs. These steep cliffs are perfect nesting habitat for seabirds such as cormorants and western gulls. Atop the island the tiny island fox reigns as the largest land mammal. The isolated beaches provide resting places for three species of pinnipeds (seals and sea lions)--northern elephant seals, harbor seals and California sea lions.

Dense undersea kelp forests surround the island providing food and shelter for many species of fish, invertebrates, and once again--for sea otters. Pristine tidepools ring the island's rocky shores where crabs, abalone, sea urchins and sea snails have adapted to their ever-changing homes. San Nicolas Island is typical of the islands in the Channel Islands archipelago--but it is also unique.

A Military Presence

Since 1933, San Nicolas Island has been under the jurisdiction of the U. S. Navy. Approximately 400 people work and staff the island. San Nicolas is part of the Pacific Missile Test Center's Sea Test Range. Navy personnel work on projects such as missile tracking and weapon system testing. A 10,000 foot runway accomodates supersonic target aircraft and planes from the mainland during operations. Facilities for island

Illustration courtesy National Park Service



personnel include a bowling alley, cafeteria and a hobby shop. Because of the military operations, visitation by the general public is prohibited.

The natural resources of San Nicolas Island are managed by a joint agreement between the Department of the Navy, the Department of the Interior and California's Department of Fish and Game.

The U. S. Fish and Wildlife Service is currently working on a sea otter recovery program on the island. Once abundant around all the Channel Islands, sea otters were hunted to extinction for their valuable pelts. Biologists working on the sea otter project relocate animals from the Monterey Bay population in hopes that a colony of otters will be established once again in southern California.

ers spend considerable time investigating areas where the elements have exposed burial sites from the Indian inhabitants. Once the sites are researched, the remains are carefully re-buried where, it is hoped, they will remain undisturbed by the elements in future years.

About the Author:

John P. Harrigan graduated from Cal Poly Pomona in June, 1970. He is a Licensed Electrical Engineer for the Los Angeles Department of Water and Power. John says he enjoys working in the department's old hydro-electric power plants, some of which date back to 1908.

John is a member of the Scenic Mount Lowe Historical Committee and a volunteer with the U. S. Forest Service working on the preservation of the old Mount Lowe Railway System in the mountains above Altadena, California.

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7. Emma C. Hardacre, *Eighteen Years Alone*, (Santa Barbara, 1850), p. 4. (Reprinted from *Scribner's Monthly*).

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Chumash elder Rafael Solares in traditional clothing was photographed in 1877 by Leon de Cessac, a French scientist who studied archaeological sites of the Chumash Indians.

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